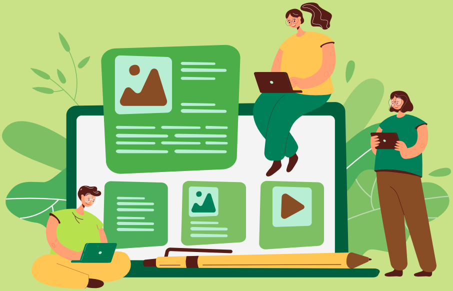
Visual Design Principles & Trends



What we will learn today?

1. Visual Design Principles
2. Basic Design Principles
3. Why Principles Matter in UI Design
4. Current Popular Desing Trends
5. Design Trends Vs Design Principles
6. Figma Task - Apply Principles & Trend of Your Choice

Visual Design Principles

Visual Design Principles

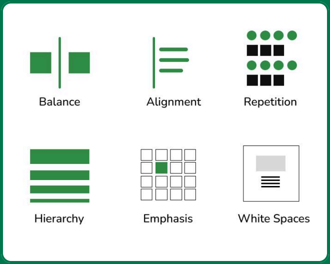
Fundamental rules that help create visually appealing, balanced, and easy-to-use interfaces.

Principles are like the grammar of design — they guide how we place, space, and style elements to create clarity and impact.

Basic Design Principles

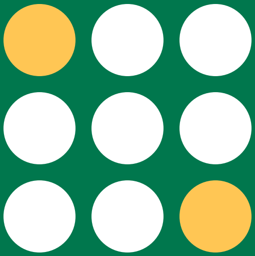
Basic Design Principles

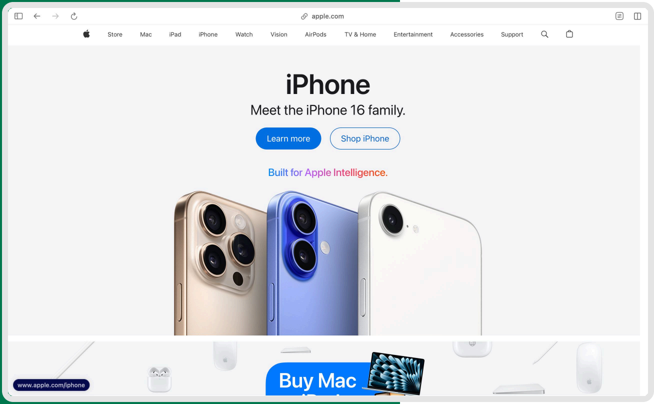
1. Balance
2. Contrast
3. Emphasis
4. Movement
5. Hirerachy
6. White Space
7. Proximity
8. Alignment
9. Consistency
10. Repetition


Balance
Alignment
Repetition
Hierarchy
Emphasis
White Spaces

Balance

- Distribute visual weight evenly. Can be symmetrical (formal) or asymmetrical (dynamic but still balanced).
- Don’t let your design feel heavy on one side.
- Keep things arranged evenly so it feels neat.




apple.com
Store
Mac
iPad
iPhone
Watch
Vision
AirPods
TV & Home
Entertainment
Accessories
Support
Learn more
Shop iPhone
Buy Mac
www.apple.com/iphone

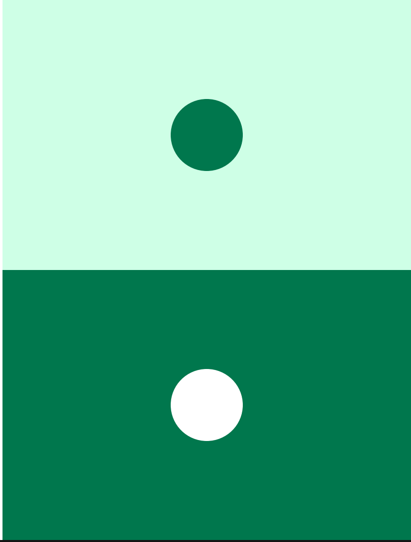
iPhone

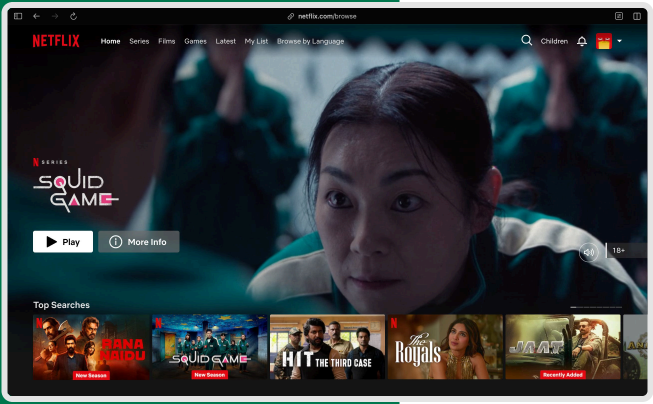
Meet the iPhone 16 family.

Built for Apple Intelligence.

Contrast

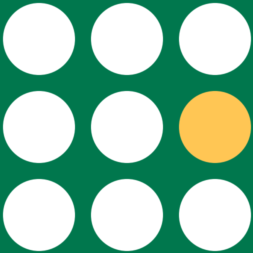
- Use color, size, or shape differences to create hierarchy and clarity.
- Use dark and light, big and small to show what's important.
- Example: White text on a black background stands out.

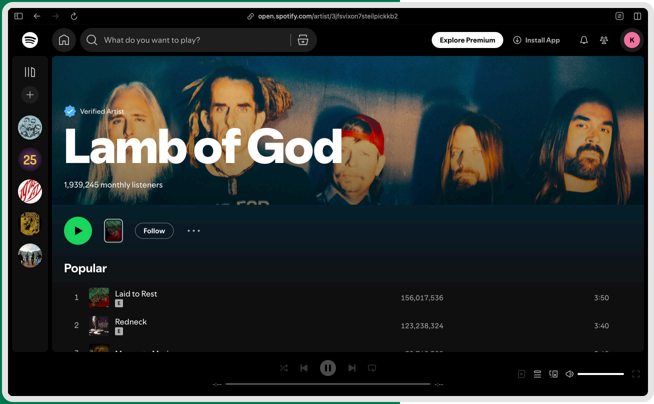



netflix.com/browse
NETFLIX
Home
Series
Films
Games
Latest
My List
Browse by Language
Children
SERIES
SQUID GAME
Play
More Info
18+
Top Searches
RANA NAIDU
New Season
SQUID GAME
New Season
HIT THE THIRD CASE
The Royals
JAAT
Recently Added

Emphasis

- Guide the user's attention to the most important elements — like CTAs or headlines.
- Make one thing pop so people notice it first.
- Example: A bright "Buy Now" button or bold heading.

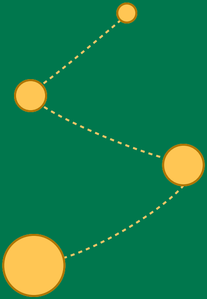


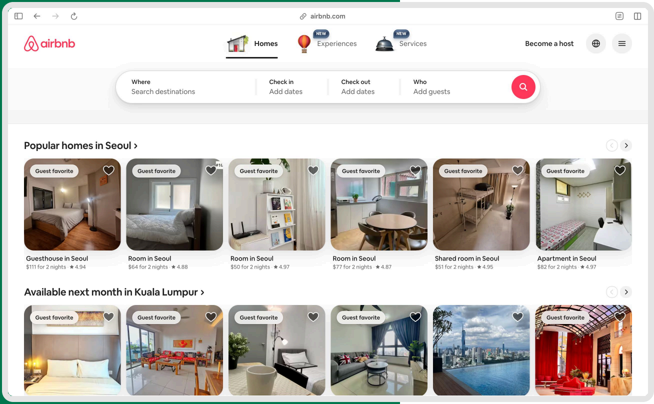

open.spotify.com/artist/3jfsvixon7steilpickkb2
What do you want to play?
Explore Premium
Install App
K
25
Verified Artist
Lamb of God
1,939,245 monthly listeners
Follow
Popular

1	Laid to Rest E	156,017,536	3:50
2	Redneck E	123,238,324	3:40

Movement

- Design guides the user's eye through content naturally, often top to bottom or left to right.
- Arrange things so eyes naturally move across the screen.
- Example: Top to bottom or left to right reading flow.




airbnb.com
airbnb
Homes
NEW
Experiences
NEW
Services
Become a host
Where
Search destinations
Check in
Add dates
Check out
Add dates
Who
Add guests
Guest favorite

Popular homes in Seoul ›

Guesthouse in Seoul
$111 for 2 nights · ★ 4.94

Room in Seoul
$64 for 2 nights · ★ 4.88

Room in Seoul
$50 for 2 nights · ★ 4.97

Room in Seoul
$77 for 2 nights · ★ 4.87

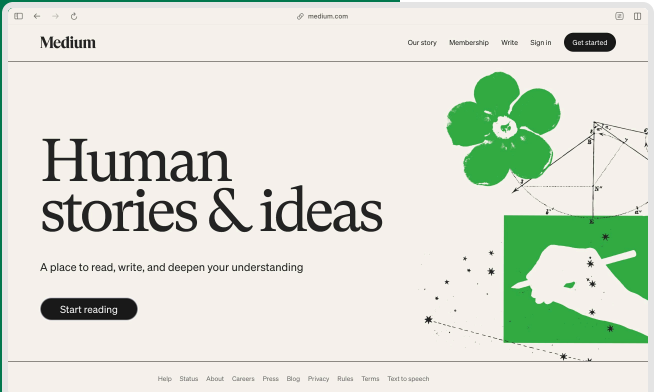
Shared room in Seoul
$51 for 2 nights · ★ 4.95

Apartment in Seoul
$82 for 2 nights · ★ 4.97

Available next month in Kuala Lumpur ›

Hierarchy

- Use size, color, and position to show what’s most important.
- Example: Big headings, medium subheadings, smaller body text.

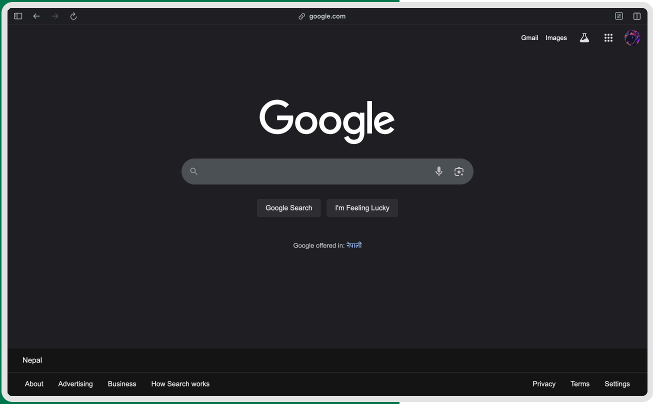

medium.com
Medium
Our story
Membership
Write
Sign in
Get started
Start reading
Help
Status
About
Careers
Press
Blog
Privacy
Rules
Terms
Text to speech

Human stories & ideas

A place to read, write, and deepen your understanding

White Space

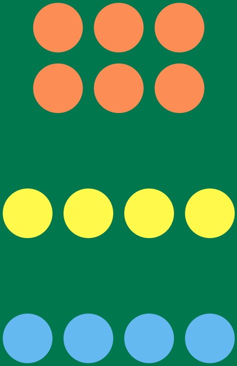
- Empty space around elements improves clarity and prevents clutter.
- Empty space is good — it helps avoid a messy, crowded look.
- It makes your design easy to read and looks clean.

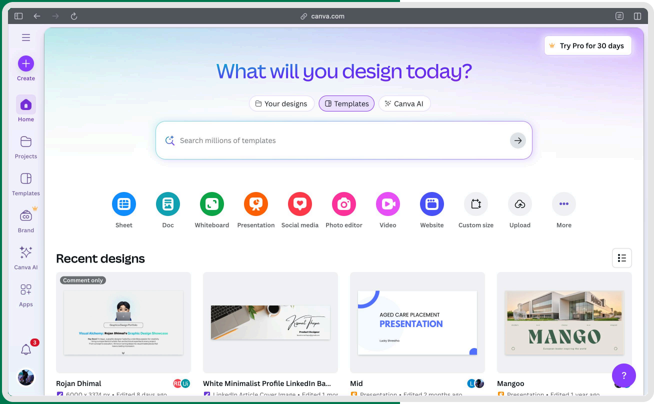


google.com
Gmail
Images
Google
Google Search
I'm Feeling Lucky
Google offered in: नेपाली
Nepal
About
Advertising
Business
How Search works
Privacy
Terms
Settings

Proximity

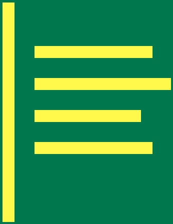
- Proximity refers to how close elements are to one another
- Group related items together, separate unrelated ones.
- Example: Form fields close to their labels, but space between sections.

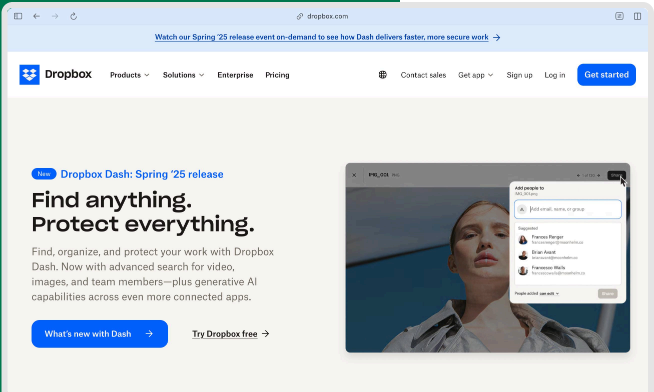



canva.com
Create
Home
Projects
Templates
Brand
Canva AI
Apps
3
Try Pro for 30 days
What will you design today?
Your designs
Templates
Canva AI
Search millions of templates
Sheet
Doc
Whiteboard
Presentation
Social media
Photo editor
Video
Website
Custom size
Upload
More
Recent designs
Comment only
AGED CARE PLACEMENT
PRESENTATION
MANGO
Rojan Dhimal
6000 x 3374 px • Edited 8 days ago
White Minimalist Profile LinkedIn Ba...
LinkedIn Article Cover Image • Edited 1 mon
Mid
Presentation • Edited 2 months ago
Mangoo
Presentation • Edited 1 year ago
?

Alignment

- Alignment means the arrangement of elements along an axis.
- Keep elements lined up neatly — it looks professional and feels organized.
- Example: Text and buttons aligned to the same grid.




dropbox.com
Dropbox
Products
Solutions
Enterprise
Pricing
Contact sales
Get app
Sign up
Log in
Get started
New
IMG_001 PNG
1 of 120
Share
Add people to
IMG_001.png
Add email, name, or group
Suggested
Frances Renger
francesrenger@moonhelm.co
Brian Avant
brianavant@moonhelm.co
Francesco Walls
francescowalls@moonhelm.co
People added can edit
Share
What's new with Dash
Try Dropbox free

Watch our Spring '25 release event on-demand to see how Dash delivers faster, more secure work →

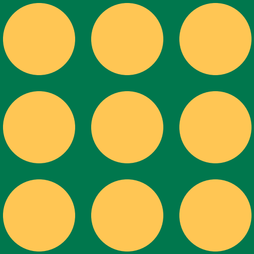
Dropbox Dash: Spring '25 release

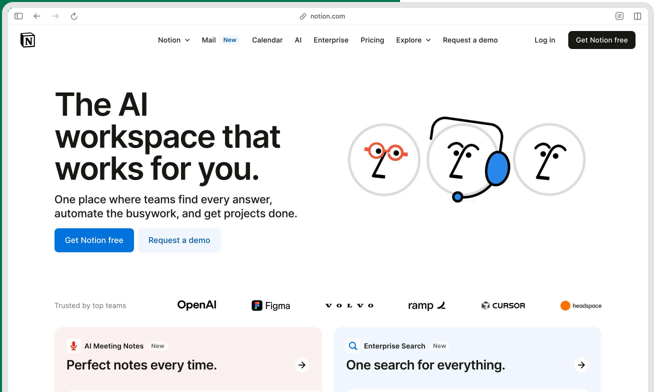
Find anything.
Protect everything.

Find, organize, and protect your work with Dropbox Dash. Now with advanced search for video, images, and team members—plus generative AI capabilities across even more connected apps.

Consistency

- Maintaining consistent use of colors, typography, icons, spacing, and overall layout patterns
- Keep design styles the same across your product.
- Example: Same color for all clickable links or icons that match in style.





notion.com

Notion Mail New Calendar AI Enterprise Pricing Explore Request a demo Log in Get Notion free

The AI workspace that works for you.

One place where teams find every answer, automate the busywork, and get projects done.

Get Notion free Request a demo

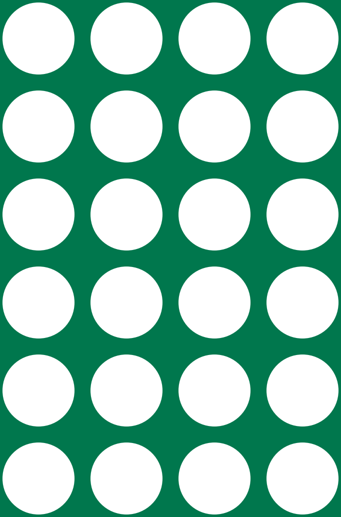
Trusted by top teams OpenAI Figma VOLVO ramp CURSOR headspace

AI Meeting Notes New

Perfect notes every time.

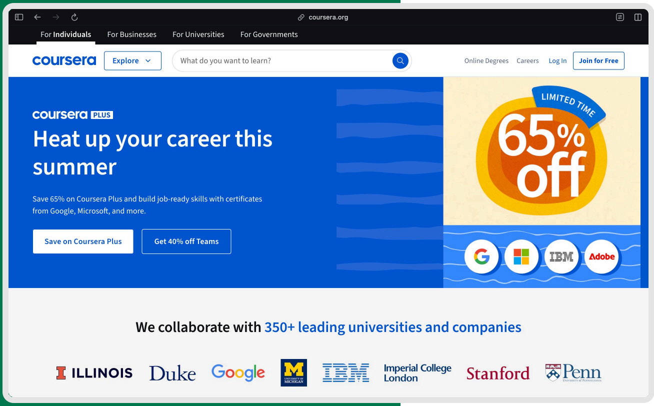
Enterprise Search New

One search for everything.



Repetition

- Repeat visual styles (colors, fonts, icons) for consistency and brand recognition.
- Repeating colors, fonts, or styles to keep everything looking connected.
- It makes your design feel organized and professional.


coursera.org
For Individuals
For Businesses
For Universities
For Governments
coursera
Explore
What do you want to learn?
Online Degrees
Careers
Log In
Join for Free
coursera PLUS
Save on Coursera Plus
Get 40% off Teams
LIMITED TIME
65% off

Heat up your career this summer

Save 65% on Coursera Plus and build job-ready skills with certificates from Google, Microsoft, and more.

We collaborate with 350+ leading universities and companies

Why Principles Matter in UI Design

Why Principles Matter in UI Design

- Makes the design clear and easy to use

- Helps users know where to look and what to do
- Keeps everything looking consistent and professional
- Improves readability and focus
- Builds user trust and a better experience

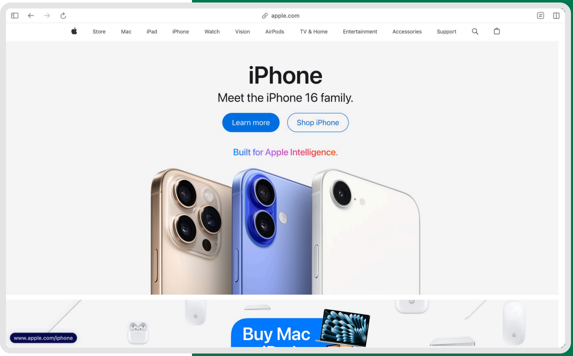
Current Popular Design Trends

Current Popular Design Trends

1. Minimalism
2. Dark Mode
3. Neumorphism
4. Glassmorphism
5. Bold Typography
6. Micro - Interactions
7. Mobile-First, Responsive Design

Minimalism

- Clean, simple interfaces with lots of white space
- Focus on essential content only
- Example: Apple, Airbnb


apple.com
Store
Mac
iPad
iPhone
Watch
Vision
AirPods
TV & Home
Entertainment
Accessories
Support
Learn more
Shop iPhone
Buy Mac
www.apple.com/iphone

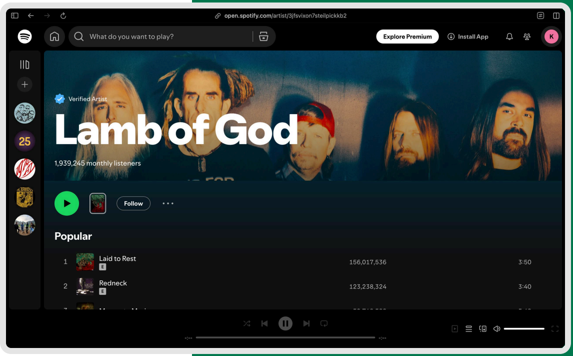
iPhone

Meet the iPhone 16 family.

Built for Apple Intelligence.

Dark Mode

- Light text on dark backgrounds for modern, eye-friendly design.
- Example: Spotify, Instagram


open.spotify.com/artist/3jfsvixon7steilpickkb2
What do you want to play?
Explore Premium
Install App
K
25
Verified Artist
Follow
Popular

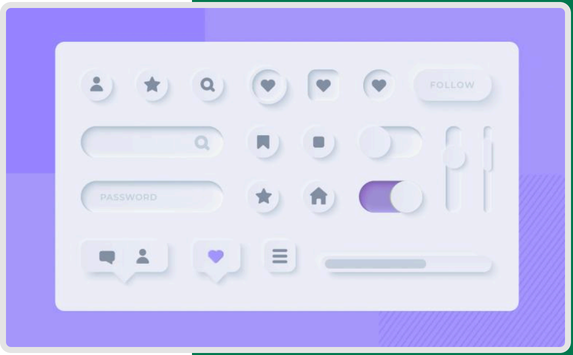
Lamb of God

1,939,245 monthly listeners

1	Laid to Rest E	156,017,536	3:50
2	Redneck E	123,238,324	3:40

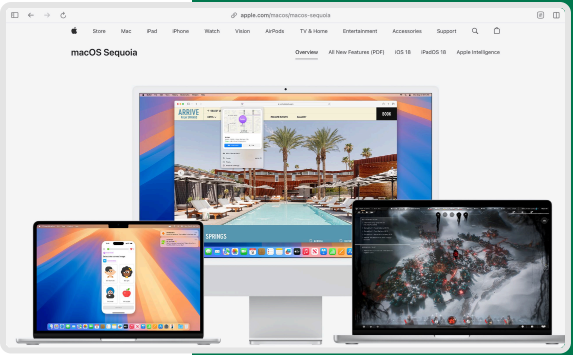
Neumorphism

- Frosted glass, blurred backgrounds, and semi-transparent elements.
- Example: Modern Dashboard


FOLLOW
PASSWORD

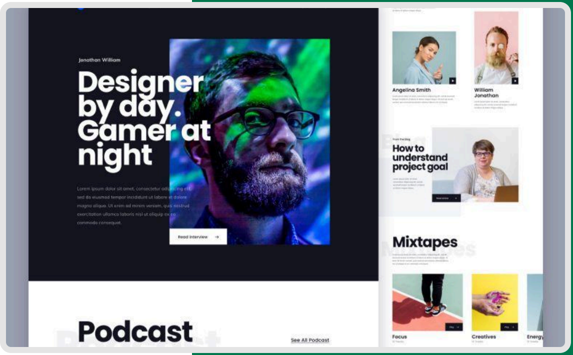
Glassmorphism

- Frosted glass, blurred backgrounds, and semi-transparent elements.
- Example: Mac OS


apple.com/macos/macos-sequoia
Store
Mac
iPad
iPhone
Watch
Vision
AirPods
TV & Home
Entertainment
Accessories
Support
macOS Sequoia
Overview
All New Features (PDF)
iOS 18
iPadOS 18
Apple Intelligence
ARRIVE
PALM SPRINGS
BOOK
SPRINGS

Bold Typography

- Large, eye-catching fonts for emphasis
- Minimal graphics, focus on words
- Example: Stripe, Asana landing pages



Jonathan William

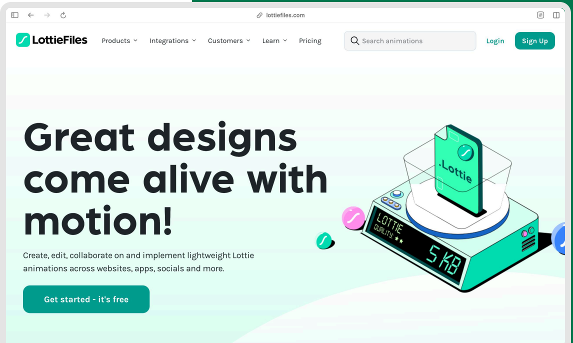
Designer by day. Gamer at night

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit, sed do eiusmod tempor incididunt ut labore et dolore magna aliqua. Ut enim ad minim veniam, quis nostrud exercitation ullamco laboris nisi ut aliquip ex ea commodo consequat.

Read interview
Podcast
See All Podcast
Angelina Smith
William Jonathan
How to understand project goal
Mixtapes
Focus
Creatives
Energy

Micro – Interactions

- Small animations like button clicks, hover effects, or loading animations that improve user experience.
- Example : Lottiefiles



lottiefiles.com
LottieFiles
Products
Integrations
Customers
Learn
Pricing
Search animations
Login
Sign Up

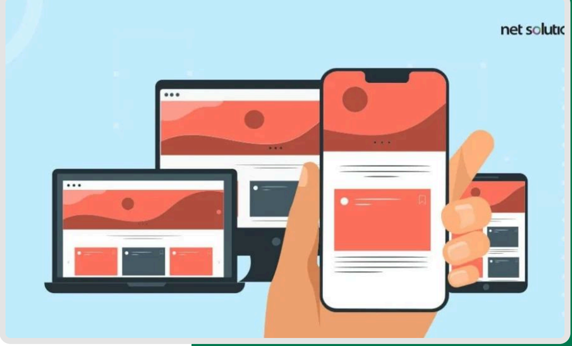
Great designs come alive with motion!

Create, edit, collaborate on and implement lightweight Lottie animations across websites, apps, socials and more.

Get started - it's free
.Lottie
LOTTIE QUALITY ★★
5 KB

Mobile-First, Responsive Design

- Design for mobile screens first, then scale for larger devices.
- Example: Most modern websites and apps


net solutic

We'll dive deeper next class! >

Design Trends Vs Design Principles

Design Trends Vs Design Principles

Design Principles → Foundation

- Make the design clear, structured, easy to use.

- Examples: Balance, Contrast, Alignment, Hierarchy.

- Trends build on top of Principles

Design Trends → Style/Look

- Make the design feel modern and attractive.
- Examples: Minimalism, Dark Mode, Glassmorphism.

Design Principles = Your Bike Riding Skills

- Balance, Control, Braking, Steering — these are your core skills.
- Without them, you can't ride safely, no matter where you ride.

Design Trends = The Road or Racing Track

- Smooth highway, off-road trail, racing track — these change.
- But your riding skills (principles) apply everywhere.

The Connection

- If you know how to ride (follow design principles), you can confidently ride on any track (apply any design trend).
- But if you only focus on the road style (trend) and forget the basics, you'll crash — your design looks cool but fails for users.

"Trends change like roads — but design principles are your riding skills. Master the skills first!"